forcibly lift him from the stage and hospitalize him. But in a parallel process, then law minister Veerappa Moily claimed he had got the go-ahead from Sonia Gandhi to negotiate with Team Anna. Moily initiated talks with Swami Agnivesh who was part of Hazare's group but also had an excellent relationship with the government. By 8 April, as the fast entered its fourth day, Moily drafted an agreement to set up a ten-member drafting committee to prepare a fresh Lok Pal Bill. The committee would have five ministers from the government and five representatives chosen by Hazare. It was seen as a compromise solution, but it was a bad compromise which only legitimized Hazare and his team as the official interlocutors on behalf of civil society. 'It was typical of our confused mind. The left hand did not know what the right hand was doing,' admits a former Cabinet minister.

Hazare called off his fast the next morning, but the government's limitations and weakness had been exposed. Three months later, the same government would be brought to its knees as a charged-up Hazare decided to take his agitation to another level by threatening to launch another fast if the Lok Pal Bill was not passed by 15 August. As the deadline approached, the confrontation worsened. On 13 August, Hazare wrote to the prime minister asking him 'to show courage' and instruct the Delhi police to allow him to go ahead with the proposed fast at JP Park in central Delhi. The prime minister declined to intervene.

Then something quite inexplicable happened. A US state department report appeared to back Hazare's agitation and called on the Indian government to exercise 'democratic restraint' in dealing with the anti-corruption protestors. It left ministers and Congress leaders fulminating. 'Who is Washington to talk to us like this, we must hit back,' said one minister.

A meeting of senior party and government leaders was called on the night of 13 August at the Congress war room in Gurudwara Rakabganj Road. Rahul Gandhi was yet to return from the US where Sonia was undergoing treatment. At the meeting, the consensus was: 'We must expose the Anna movement.' Congress spokesperson Manish Tewari, who had left for